

to me, that must be the remnants of him. Whatever's left of him. And the Color Out Of Space must be a servant or something of the entity that he claims lies beyond the Gate."

"And what is this entity?" Vilde asks. "Where did it come from?"

"As I'm sure you all know, sorcerers like me draw power from our bloodline," Raphael explained. "The entity must be the thing that infused my family's bloodline with Its power. As to where it came from, I have no clue, but it must lie beyond the Gate. The search of It has been my family's motto, mission really, since I was a little boy." Turning to Thaisha, Raphael continues, "This ship is my father's. They crashed here, and when I went for the box we were all sucked into my head. Here's the strange thing: the Color Out Of Space did not hurt me. I was caught in the wave of its Color Blast and it didn't hurt me, just gave me my colors back. I'm not sure why, too."

"And this entity, it has a name?" Wang Lei asked. "Is it still a threat to us?"

Raphael nodded. "Yog-So'Thoth. And for your second question, I'm not sure. Maybe."

Having been quiet inspecting the contents of the box, Hazel, Thaisha and Salazar sees a circlet of gnarled onyx, with purple barbs designed to dig into the head of the wearer. Beneath it, a monstrous-looking tome bound in humanoid skin with an almost palpable aura of dread. There is a grotesque and ghoulish face stretched across its loathsome cover.

"That's the Nekronomicon," Raphael says. "I think he was reading up on it. In any case, he might have left me clues at Nagalore. We should probably find some time to head there."

"And what clues might that be?" Thaisha asks. "Are you trying to find this... Yog-So'Thoth? Open the Gate and bring It here?"

"It's my family's goal to find out the truth," Raphael lies. "I think I need more information than that. For all I know, my father could be lying."

#### WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a nat 20 check, Thaisha sees right through Raphael.

"And are you going to open the Gate or not?" Hazel asks. "Your father said not to do it, back in your mind."

"I will need more information," He says. "I can't say for sure - "

"I'm not going to Nagalore," Thaisha shoots a look at Wang Lei and Hazel. "I am not helping you Open the

Gate so that an otherworldy entity can break into our world. Are you? Or you? Or any of you?" She points at Wang Lei and Hazel, before gesturing to the rest of the Party.

"Well, if we do, we can kill it," Wang Lei responds. A tense silence falls over the group.

"In any case, it is not a pressing matter," Vilde speaks up. "We need to focus on the problem at hand." She produces the letter from Lord Atakan Tokugane, passing it around to the others.

Reading the letter, Salazar shares with the Party what he knows about the Court of Owls. He shares an urban myth he has heard about them as an international organisation of assassins who seek to bring order to the world. Vilde shares her conclusions, but remains unsure if Lord Atakan's plot to seize control of the organisation was successful.

Discussion over what the Court of Owls is continues in earnest. Nobody sees Raphael unfurl a small note that had been left in the box which he had kept to himself. The note is simple; written in his father's handwriting are the words: "Raphael. September 29, 790 AY. Scorching Sands. Black dragon's blood will Open the Way."

Vilde. Your Sending stone pings.

"YOUR LETTERS ARE HERE!" Firebeard's voice rings out from the stone. "ALSO, YOU HAVE VISITORS. THE LADY ARIANWEN HAS ARRIVED. SHE IS ASKING TO SEE VILDE."

"Oh, no," the rogue says, fishing the stone out of her pocket. Instinctively, she says into the stone. "Did they bring my scimitars, and also did my mum look angry?"

The stone does not respond.

"WAH," Vilde curses. "He's deaf!"

## ACTIONS OVER WORDS

With the revelation that your letters are here, and having resolved to head back to Camp Vengeance, all of you decide to take an early night and make haste on the journey back. Even taking the same route you took here and travelling at top speed, it is still about three days' journey.

After a rather uneventful day of travelling along the Aldani Basin, all of you begin your nightly routine. Wukong - you find a rare sight in your bedroom: Thaisha is sitting on your bed.

"I know we haven't spoken much," the half-orc says as the paladin enters. "But I think the number of people in the Party that I can trust is dwindling."

"What are you here for?" Wukong enquires.

"You're a paladin," Thaisha replies. "You can literally *Detect Good and Evil*. How many of our friends do you think seek to save the world? Protect the innocent? Defend those who cannot defend themselves?"

"We are here on this quest together," Wukong urges. "And yes, even though we all have our own different motivations, we are all here, focused on achieving our goals."

"We may be united in our pursuit to destroy the Devourer," Thaisha concedes. "But how many of them do you think want to do the opposite? Take advantage of the innocent? Covet power?"

"I see the good in everyone," Wukong says. "And I think even though some of our friends are keeping some cards close to the vest and holding secrets of their own, we are ultimately good people."

"I have my own eyes, Wukong, I can see what you refuse to. I can see the Party give zero shit that Ayo is dead. I can see Raphael is intent on unleashing this... Yog-So'Thoth. I can see that nobody cared that we sent a bunch of dangerous frost giants on Yandala's path. And, beyond the general apathy, I can see what we both agree on: that almost everybody has something to hide. But do you know who has nothing to hide? Do you know who is still a child, and should not be subject to the horrors of our journey thus far? Who have had to take a life, despite not wanting to? Who needs protection, not only from sorcerers masquerading as clerics of the Light, but also the reckless decisions made by those loudest in the Party?"

Wukong remains silent.

"Hazel... is a special girl," Thaisha shares. "I think she really might be the best of us. She's kind and she's diligent and she's whip smart. But here's the thing - I don't think the Party cares. I think all they see, is a cute, stupid little rabbit that is only good for healing spells and summoning *Spirit Guardians*. Why else are we going to Camp Vengeance now, even though we agreed on going to Tamochan and then Raya? If we can change the Party's next stop so easily, why didn't we go to Mezro, with Yandala?"

"What do you want?" Wukong asks.

"I'm not in here to change your mind, or to win you over, or to convince you to go to Tamoachan," Thaisha continues. "I believe I don't need to do that. I believe, in time, you will see what I see, that this group of people are no heroes. I am here because I want your word. I

want you to swear to me that you will defend Hazel. Not just in words, but in deed as well."

"This quest, to destroy the Devourer, is going to be one we can't do alone," Wukong emphasizes. "We need to stick together, work together as a team."

"I agree," Thaisha says. "But I don't want people to be taken advantage of just because they are quiet."

Wukong ponders this for a moment, before saying, "I'm sworn to defend the good. And I will continue to do that."

"And if those in your Party become bad?" Thaisha urges. "Will you stop them then? If Raphael chooses to Open the Gate, what would you do?"

"We don't know that he wants to do that," Wukong points out.

"Well, you can," Thaisha continues. "You can literally *Zone of Truth* him. But again, I'm not here to debate whether or not he will. I'm just asking if you will stand up and stop those who have nefarious intent, even if they are your friends."

Wukong nods.

"Swear to it," Thaisha urges.

"I will," Wukong promises.

#### WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC15 check, Wukong sees a small smirk cross Thaisha's face. While not malevolent, he intuits that she is happy that she has recruited the paladin on her side.

"Goodnight, Wukong," Thaisha gets up and leaves.

Vilde, you hear a rapt knock on her door. Looking up, you see Mason. He has his armour off, and is wearing a very simple tunic. Dangling off his neck, the squire is still wearing the *Locket of the Stolen Heart*.

"M'lady," Mason says. "A word."

"Oh, yes, please," Vilde says. "Come in."

Mason enters the room, shutting the door behind himself. "I've been trying my best to follow along with what's happening, but I sense that there are things you do not wish to share with the group. If I may be so bold m'lady... what is the *Court of Owls*?"

"Oh, of course I can share this with you," Vilde says. "You're the closest to me here. I believe it is a group of people trying to change the world for the better."

“And you’d like to keep it a secret?” Mason asks.

“I think some people in the Party may have a misunderstanding against this organisation,” Vilde continues carefully. “They may not fully understand the Court, and therefore may act aggressively. We don’t know each person’s main goal, and to be honest I don’t want to reveal all our cards.”

“Who do you think in particular?” Mason asks. “Do you think Salazar is our friend?”

“I’ve known him for quite a while, since our days in the mainland,” Vilde says. “He strikes me as someone who’s trying to find out more about who he is. I don’t think he’s evil, but when he finds out what his past is... we don’t know if he might turn.”

Mason looks visibly troubled by the overwhelming load of information.

“It’s okay, Mason,” Vilde encourages the squire. “Find Wang Lei for some training. Focus on the present. I’ll handle it.”

At the mention of Wang Lei, Mason looks depressed. “That’s another matter entirely,” Mason says. “I-I feel like I’m struggling to keep up with the group, and now that we’re headed back to Camp Vengeance, I’m afraid Sir Wang Lei might just drop me off and get a new squire. He’s a legend, but he can be hard to read sometimes.”

Vilde reaches out, rubbing Mason’s shoulder. “Don’t worry,” she purrs. “I feel the talent in you...” The rogue slips her hand down, feeling his chest. “Just keep working hard, alright. Consistency and persistence is key.”

Mason nods, getting up and taking off his shirt before heading out to train with his new *Javelin of Lightning*.

## READING THE NEKRONOMICON

Raphael. As you retire to your room, you feel a soft hum from the box. Opening the box, you see that the *Nekronomicon* is softly humming with power.

Your fingers go to part the pages of the book, but it refuses to relent. You see the eyes of the ghoulish face stretched across the cover glow with brilliant light as the mouth lets loose a terrifying scream.

Because of the eldritch nature of the *Nekronomicon*, Raphael surmises that one must be attuned to it to even be able to open it.

“Hey, Wukong,” Raphael knocks on the paladin’s door, later in the night. “Need a favour.” The sorcerer explains that he hopes to glean more information about

Yog-So’Thoth and learn if what his father had said was the truth, which would require attuning to the accursed book. He shares his concern that the book might be dangerous, and therefore seeks the paladin’s aura to be able to withstand any potential backlash by the book.

Wukong agrees, in part wanting to help his friend, and in part wanting to keep an eye on the sorcerer. They enter Raphael’s room.



Raphael. You close your eyes and feel your mind’s power stretch out across the book. Like tendrils in the dark, your mind sends out writhing probes to find weak points in the magic of the book. The psionic power inside your mind caresses the spine of the book, coaxing it to open. As it opens, you feel powerful magic pour out of the book. The magic washes over you like soft waves on the beach. You gain access to the book’s infinite secrets.

Wukong, you watch as the sorcerer crosses his legs, and begin levitating slightly in mid-air. In front of him, glowing malevolently purple, is the *Nekronomicon*. Slowly, softly, the book opens as its pages begin fluttering. You watch the magic swirl around as Raphael’s head darts around, as if searching for something.

### CHARISMA SAVING THROW

On a successful DC 20 Charisma saving throw, Raphael’s alignment does not become neutral evil.

The sorcerer begins his search for more information regarding Yog-So’Thoth, the Key and the Gate.

### INTELLIGENCE (ARCANA) CHECK

In an investigation about Yog-So'Thoth, Raphael learns that

- on a **DC 10**, that threads of fate and destiny, space and time weave together to form the Fabric of Reality. Yog-So'Thoth is an error in the Weaving. Somewhere, somehow, the threads were snagged, frayed and knotted by something beyond the Fabric. Because of this, reality is excruciatingly painful for it. It seeks a form that is not rejected by the laws that govern Reality, and has been grooming a particular bloodline to be able to withstand it by encouraging them to Open the Gate.
- on a **DC 15**, that to Open the Gate, a Key has to be used. A Key is a moment in time, and a sacrifice in space. There are three known Keys: Antaril, 20 October 753 AY; Nagalore, 15 January 775 AY; and the Scorching Sands, 29 September 791 AY, 362 days from now.

### OBSESSION

All of you awaken the next day, and start to gather around for breakfast. As all of you try to get in a quick meal before heading off, you realize that Raphael and Wukong both are not here.

Vilde, Salazar and Mason resolve to check on Raphael, as Wang Lei, Hazel and Thaisha checks on Wukong. Vilde knocks on the door, prompting Wukong to open the door.

Entering Raphael's room, all of you watch as he remains levitated, with his darting around in front of the book. Salazar, you recognize this as the process of attuning to a powerful magical object.

"How long has he been like this?" Vilde asks Wukong.

Wukong replies that "he's been like this all night," and shares what Raphael told him previously. Salazar explains that the attunement process could take up to a day.

Thaisha, Wang Lei and Hazel join the group. Witnessing this, Thaisha asks, "What the hells is he doing? Is he attuning to the *Nekronomicon*? Isn't it an evil artifact?" Thaisha shoots a look at Wukong.

"I think he's trying to control the book," Wukong explains. "Make sure it doesn't do anything bad."

Hazel steps up and tries to wake Raphael by taking her book and slamming the back of the sorcerer's head. Raphael does not respond.

"What are we going to do now?" Vilde asks. "Are we just going to stand here and wait for a day?"

Thaisha steps up to the sorcerer, and extends two fingers. Pushing him gently, the Party watches Raphael drift forward slowly like a balloon.

"Okay, that settles it," Salazar says. "Mason, maybe you can push him around."

"Yeah, good idea," the squire says. He fastens a rope around Raphael's waist, tying him to himself.

With that particular wrinkle settled, all of you pack up and head off into the jungle. After about half a day's worth of travelling, all of you stop for a rest at the top of a hill. It has been a swelteringly hot day, and most of your equipment is uncomfortably sticking to your skin. As you all sit down and rest, give me a Wisdom (Perception) check.

### WISDOM (PERCEPTION) CHECK

On a **DC 10** check, they see Arthur Cimper.

Down in the valley, several hundred feet to your south, you see that a patch of the distant, humid jungle is inexplicably coated in thick, white frost. Hanging icicles glint in the sunlight with slick, frozen mud.

The Party debates for a while, suspecting that the frost giants were responsible. Hazel asks Thaisha to wildshape into a falcon and scout the area, which she does.

Returning about forty minutes later, Thaisha says that she spotted a grievously injured Arthur and Dragonbait. She explains that the glade looks like a complete battlefield, with several flash-frozen tri-flower assassin vines around them. The saurian paladin is missing an arm, and they both look like they are on the verge of death.

While Thaisha and Wukong wants to help the pair, the rest of the Party is uncertain about slowing down. Thaisha tells them that if they wish to head on first they can, but she will tend to them and meet the Party at Camp Vengeance.

Hazel breaks the tie, rallying the rest of the Party to find the pair.

Entering the glade, they see Arthur trying to set up camp for a dazed Dragonbait. The paladin is not only missing an arm, but staring blankly into the sky. Arthur is surprised to see the Party, and shares what happened since their departure three days ago. He explains that after meeting with the Party, the pair headed to the nearest *Webway* to return to the Heart. As they approached, they spotted figurines in red flying into it. Concerned, the pair opted for a stealthy approach into

the Heart to evict the squatters. Unfortunately, the powerful Shadowmantle twins repelled the pair, cutting off Dragonbait's arm in the process. They were recovering in the glade to prepare for an assault on the Heart, but were ambushed by the tri-flower fronds in their sleep.

Salazar reveals that they had already been to the Heart, and had already destroyed the Shadowmantle twins. Overjoyed, Arthur tells Dragonbait that they can make their way back into the safety of the Heart of Ubtao and rest up there before continuing on their journey. He explains that the saurial paladin can regrow his arm, but will likely take a couple of days to do so.

Wukong shares that the Party is headed to Camp Vengeance, and invites the pair along. Arthur shares that, on Dragonbait's suggestion, the pair plan to head to Kirsabal's Rest, where it is rumoured that there is a powerful healer performing miracles using a lotus lantern amongst the aarakocras there. He explains that while it is trivial to free Alisandra by chopping down the tree at the Heart of Ubtao using Entropy's Bloom, the necromantic energies radiating from the Engine has infused the elf's body, and her freedom would likely mean death. Arthur seeks to have this healer release her of the energies.

The Party passes him a *Sending* stone, telling him to keep in touch. He tells them that he will, and looks at the dazed Dragonbait who is still staring at the sky. "He, uh, might not join us at Camp Vengeance. I'll let you guys know."

Bidding the pair goodbye, the rest of you continue your journey. The rest of the day's trek remains relatively uneventful. That night, after you all set up the Commander's Tent, you all gather for dinner.

After dinner, Raphael, you feel the magic from the book recede. Your skin feels cool to the touch as the attunement process finally completes. The power of your psyche, which has been lifting you previously, puts you down gently.

Strangely, you notice that parts of your skin remain warm. Your neck, your left hand, your back, and the inside of your mouth feels... hot. As your mind's attention draws to it, it feels hotter and hotter.

You look down at your hand, and see the spot that is burning. It looks like something is moving under the skin. You feel the flesh in your hand harden and solidify as the skin splits apart, revealing a wet, bulbous eye. With a sickening pop, you feel three other eyes appear around your body.

Finding himself in his room, with Wukong missing, the sorcerer freaks out at the four new eyes he has grown. He quickly tries to cover up most of them, before heading out of his room to find Wukong, who fills him in on the events of the past day.

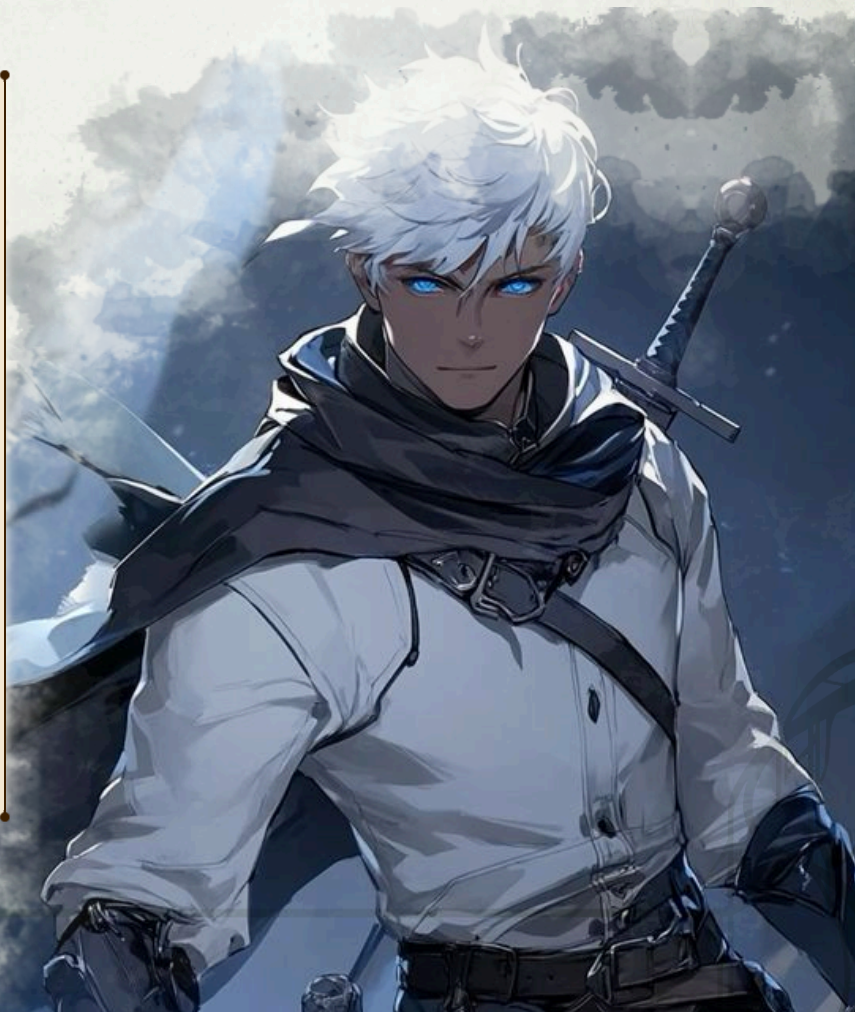
Salazar, you hear a knock on your door. Opening the door, you see Mason's towering form in the doorway.

"Hi Mr Black," Mason says. "May I come in?"

As you step aside to let him enter, he shuts the door behind himself and locks it. "I just wanted to speak to you in private. As I'm sure you've noticed, several members of our Party have been coming at Vilde for this Court of Owls business. I, uh, sense that we share a certain... fondness for her. I was hoping I could count on you to help defend her, especially when someone comes at her again."

Salazar ponders the offer. "I think you're mistaken. I don't share the same fondness you have of her. But I do think that we should respect each other's privacy. I will do my best to guard this... little secret of hers, but if I find myself at the short end of a stick, then no promises."

Mason's brilliant blue eyes look at the wizard and nods. He leaves the room, leaving Salazar to his own thoughts.



In the morning, the Party gathers for breakfast. As Hazel starts cooking, Wukong takes the opportunity to talk to the group.

"I think there has been a lot of secrets and disagreement bubbling under the surface," Wukong continues. "And, to be honest, I think we really need to work together to be able to destroy the Devourer. To do that, we need trust, and I don't like how every time someone mistrusts another person, they demand I cast *Zone of Truth*." As the paladin says that, divine energy radiates out from the simian over the group. "I'm going to cast it one more time now. Let's get it all out there."

Vilde, Mason, and Salazar resists the spell, while Raphael, Wang Lei and Thaisha willingly fails. Wukong shares this with the Party.

"So, what's up with your hand?" Thaisha asks.

"I'm about to say it, you prick," the sorcerer snarls. He removes the bandage on his hand, showing the newly formed eye. Salazar spots another eye in the inside of Raphael's mouth as he continues his tirade. "I'm sick of this. You've been coming at me non-stop since the Wreck. Do you even realize that I have had to see my father, who is now dead? I have barely enough time to process that, and you keep coming at me."

Thaisha raises an eyebrow, looking at Wukong.

"And?" Wukong asks. "Are you going to Open the Gate?"

"I don't know," Raphael replies. "Opening the Gate has been my family's motto. It has been my mission since I was a kid. And, now? My father tells me it has all been a lie. I need a minute to get my bearings."

"Hiding behind 'I don't know' seems pretty convenient," Thaisha continues, not looking at Raphael and only looking at Wukong. "I don't know about you, but it sure doesn't sound like an answer to me."

"I think we should all calm down a bit," Salazar continues. He winks at Thaisha, and points in his own mouth, hinting her to look at the eye inside of Raphael's mouth. "We don't know if he's doing anything evil or not."

"Do you think growing out random eyes on different parts of your body is something natural and good?" Grossed out, Thaisha shoots a look at Vilde. "Then again, nobody knows what you think," She continues. "You've resisted the *Zone of Truth*. Why? You got something to hide? You've been stealing our panties, or something?"

"No, I haven't," Salazar says, appalled.

"Yeah, well, we don't know, do we?" Thaisha retorts. "Since you resisted the spell."

"Back to the topic," Wukong presses Raphael. "Are you going to Open the Gate?"

"I'm going to want more information before I make a decision," Raphael confesses. "Opening the Gate might indeed release the Entity, but that's a year from now, at the very least. I'm not the kind to make rash decisions."

Vilde pauses and asks what has been rolling in her head for a while, "If you Open the Gate, and the Entity comes," The rogue says carefully. "What would you do if it attacks us?"

"Is it attacking me?" Raphael asks.

Vilde does not reply.

## RETURN TO CAMP VENGEANCE

As the contentious morning wraps up, all of you continue your journey. Returning back to Camp Vengeance, the first thing you see is a small navy of rowboats along the river. The last time you were here, it was four row boats hitched to a small wooden stake - now, you suspect there are dozens more floating along the river. There are so many that you see, in rebuilding the Camp, they had had to move it slightly more inland.

You also see that the crude timber fortification you have left behind has been substantially built up into a full stockade. The walls are much sturdier, as if they had been reinforced with treated wood, and there are more people on the watchtowers.

Even from outside, you can see that this place is now well and truly crowded. There are full-on buildings here now, houses and huts built from actual wood lined up in front of a massive bastion instead of tents. Soldiers train in the jousting field; there is a small farm, and even a bazaar.

As you step up to the Eastern Gate, Raphael you feel a forcefield of some kind buffet you backwards.

"Uh," Raphael says. "It's the blade." He produces the *Crimson Rapier*, waving it to the group. "It's cursed; I have to be invited into residences."

As all of you continue your shenanigans at the front of the Gate, you see the Knight Gaya Seramai stride out to greet all of you.

"How have you been doing, boss?" Knight Seramai greets the Party, saluting Wang Lei. "And of course, the rest of our fabled heroes. I trust your journey back thus far has been safe?"

“Uh, can you invite him in?” Wang Lei asks. “Long story.”

“Of course, boss, please, come in!” Seremai exclaims. The Party enters the new and improved Camp Vengeance.

“Yeah, well, let me give you the lay of the land,” the knight continues. “As you can see, things have been pretty busy around here, all thanks to the lot of you. After you guys dealt with the False Hydra, and um, you know,” the knight shoots them a conspiratorial look. “We were able to finally get things going. The captain, she pulled everybody back from Mezro, putting an end to the former Castellan’s plan to start a new country.”

“Is my mother here?” Vilde asks. “And, uh, is she angry?”

A grim look passes over the knight’s face. “Yeah, the Senator is the inner bailey.” Gaya points at the huge, constructed bastion in the centre of the camp. “If I were you, I’d keep news of your return on the down low, at least until you’re ready to talk to her.” Gaya Seremai turns back to Wang Lei, continuing “speaking of, I think Captain Breakbones wants to talk to the group of you. Something about our, uh... shared project.”

“And what about the letters?” Salazar asks.

“Oh, she has them,” Gaya replies. “Wanted to make sure nobody else got to see your stuff.”

Hazel and Wukong, intrigued by the bazaar, decides to shop around for items. Mason offers to leash up the animals, taking Duo, Princess and Wang Lei’s undead girallon to the animal pens. The rest of the Party heads in to find Breakbones.

“Boss, when you get a minute,” the knight turns to Wang Lei. “Got an update on the weapons you got me researching. Come find me by the armory.”

## THE 74TH EXPEDITION

Hazel, you feel someone slam into you from the back, as you are knocked forward by your shoulder.

### WISDOM (PERCEPTION) CHECK

Wukong and Hazel, beating a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, sees a small creature in red and black robes with his hood up shoulder check Hazel. On a DC 21 check, Hazel realises that the person has stolen Hazel’s *Grimoire of Saleander*.

The creature races forward, leaping and bounding across the busy bazaar. Hazel raises her hands and invokes her last tattoo, casting *Wall of Ice*. A massive dome of freezing ice crystallizes in seconds, restraining the thief.

“Hey, hey, hey!” You see a woman dressed in all black robes with a katana strapped to her back push her way through, interposing herself between you all and the thief. Behind her, you see Sister Cyas, the Camp’s healer, looking very worried. “Look, Fiverr can be a little shit sometimes, but he doesn’t mean any harm. Just let him go, and I’ll make sure he returns whatever he took, okay?”

As the action abates, Hazel, you can now see the thief properly. Suspended in crystal, you see snow white fur, patches of brown, and two long, drooping ears you’d recognize anywhere. It is your brother.

“Yes, please,” Sister Cyas joins in. “They’re harmless. Adventuring parties such as yourselves. Forgive the little rascal.”

Hazel dissipates the *Wall of Ice*, freeing her brother.

“I’m Nakano Tokugane,” the samurai stretches her hand out. “Leader of the 74th Expedition. Now, Fiverr, return what you stole.”



“I’m helping her, you know,” Fiverr protests. “Her nose is always in that book. It’s a dangerous jungle out there, she’ll be dead in days if she ain’t keeping her eyes sharp.”



“Give me that,” Hazel says, smacking her little brother and taking back the book.

“What did I tell you about stealing stuff?” Nakano chides Fiverr. “Can’t even be out buying a potion without you starting a fight.”

“The 74th Expedition, huh?” Wukong says. “Well, we’re the 52nd. Same as you, here to stop the Graying.”

“What are you doing here?” Hazel mocks Fiverr. “If they’ve picked you, they must be running out of people to send.”

“Right,” Nakano says. “Well, we’re the last Expedition. The Chamber of Lords-Advisory is running low on funds and resources to send more Expeditions. We’re it.”

“How’d you hit me so hard?” Fiverr asks, patting Hazel down. The clever harregon settles on Hazel’s *Belt of Hill Giant Strength* and starts fiddling with it. “Where’d you get that?”

“I’ll show you,” Hazel says as she smacks her brother again, sending him flying a few feet away.

“And where’s the rest of your Party?” Wukong asks.

“Out, ranging,” She shrugs. “We’ve just passed through Port M’Kaze, and took boats up the river to Camp Vengeance. Haven’t been out there yet, so we’re thinking of foraging for food and accumulating some supplies before we head out into the jungle. Have you guys been here long?”

“Oh yeah,” Wukong shares. “We’re headed to Raya after this to try and find the Devourer.”

“Oh, interesting,” the samurai takes out a small notebook of some kind and begins recording what Wukong is saying. “And where is this, Raya?”

“Somewhere in the south of the continent,” Wukong replies.

#### WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a nat 20, Wukong sees the dilemma in the heart of Nakano Tokugane: she wants to lead the Expedition, and to succeed in it and bring glory to her house, and yet she knows that she was not the first pick, and was ultimately selected because she was expendable.

Fiverr rubs himself off, returning back to the Party.

“How’s Mum and Dad?” Hazel asks.

“Not good,” Fiverr continues. “We got evicted from the Warren. Dwarves are building some kind of lightning rail. Says the warren’s tree is in the way of the station they were planning on, so they kicked us all out and moved us to the capital. Business is as good as dead, and we’re on the streets.”

A look of firm determination passes over the harregon rogue. "We could really use a win. But it's alright. I'm here now, and ready to kick some undead butt!" Fiverr starts mock punching the air, hyping himself up.

"Yeah, well, here," Hazel takes out a platinum piece and tosses it over to her brother. "Don't spend it all in one place."

"Woah, what the heck!" Fiverr curses as he admires the huge coin. "How'd you get that?"

"I've been busy, you know," Hazel points out. She smacks him again, sending him flying once more.

"Yeah, thanks," Nakano replies. She fishes out a Sending stone, passing it to them so that the Party can keep in touch. "At any rate, I reckon we could work together, share information and everything?"

Wukong nods, taking the stone.

"See you around sis!" Fiverr leaps up onto the samurai's shoulder as the pair heads off to complete their business.

As they leave, Sister Cyas talks to Wukong and Hazel. She points out that the Camp has been really thriving, and that without no horrifying sieges by the Hag, she has started a side business selling potions of various kinds. She asks if they were still travelling with Salazar, inviting him to come to the infirmary as she wished to consult his medical expertise on a case of madness in one of their captives.

## A TENUOUS PEACE

Entering the war room, Salazar, Vilde, Raphael and Wang Lei sees Captain Breakbones pouring over a map. As all of you enter, she nods to Firebeard who walks out of the door. The doors shut behind all of you as the half-orc smiles at all of you.

"Been a while, huh?"

Breakbones updates the Party that she has sought permission from Sir Maladark Blade, the leader of the *Eyes of the Emperor* and have established a peace deal with the Merchant Princes: the Guard will withdraw from the continent after the Graying is stopped. Camp Vengeance and Fort Sempter will, in the meantime, serve as relay and supply points for all Expeditions in the area. She also shares that she has been promoted and is now the acting Castellan on the continent.

She also explains that the bounties on the 51st Expedition has been partially collected: they have captured two elves, a human boy, and an earth genasi woman.

"Who, specifically?" Raphael asks.

"Ah," Captain Breakbones replies. Checking her notes, she says, "We captured an Ariadne Govemi, a Taylor Swyft, a Gwynne Parcyr and an Eren Yeager. They are slated to be transported back to the mainland through Port M'Kaze in a few days, where they will be trialed in Leonitar. If found guilty, they will be hanged." Breakbones asks if the Party has made any progress on the hunt for Sergeant Pearne Harne, and warns that a trial is dangerous, particularly with a loose end. She says that she would love to just hang them here and now, but it is risky because she was ultimately the biggest beneficiary to Lyara Porter's death and therefore the most suspicious.

"We're on it," Wang Lei assures Breakbones. "Haven't seen him, but we're on it."

"In the meanwhile, if it's possible," Vilde asks. "Could you trouble some of your guys to try and look for them as well?"

"Well, here's the thing," Breakbones replies. "The majority of the Guard here doesn't know what happened. They believe what we said, which is that the 51st Expedition did the deed. Only those who were in Camp Vengeance at the time know the truth." She also recommends that the Party keeps the assassination and their involvement on the down low, during their time here.

"What about the Knight Gaya?" Vilde suggests.

Breakbones nods. "Yeah, now that the armoury is up, I don't see why not. I'll send him to lead a small detachment out." With business concluded, Breakbones hands out the letters for Salazar and Raphael.

Having previously sent a letter to ask if Professor Hermione McGonagall attacked him, and to learn more about his heritage, Salazar receives a letter from the Professor. McGonagall explains that she did not attack him, and spends the majority of the letter detailing matters of her estate. She postulates that she has maybe a couple of weeks left, and would intend for him to inherit her position at the Hexeverel. Attached to the letter is a copy of a filled out application, endorsed by herself, in his name for the role of Abjuration Professor.

"Your letter came with this, too," Breakbones explains. Setting a small chest on the table, Salazar discovers that McGonagall had sent over 1000 gold pieces' worth of experimental spell components and gold ink, which he would require to learn new spells.

Salazar also receives a reply from the Ring of Gold, who thank him for updating them about what happened to Dead-Eye Demodus. Unfortunately, the Ring does not know anything about the King of Feathers.

Raphael receives a lengthy letter from his grandmother, the Lady Isolde Antarra. It started by updating him of current news: the letter spoke of the destruction of Kaelen's house at the hands of House Tychonis, who now hold control over two cities. She explained that as a result of their progress, they have finalized Raphael's betrothal to Trimus and Tetra Tychonis.

#### WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a failed DC 15 check, Raphael only remembers what the twins look like and the rumours surrounding them. It was well known that the pair were highly promiscuous, and often like to sleep around together at the Society of the Six. The poor souls that would copulate with the twins were often found murdered, with a look of bliss on their faces.

The Lady Isolde Antarra also talks about how the Pontifex of the Candescent Church was assassinated at a gala, but subsequently revived miraculously. This came at a surprise to Raphael, who knows that that is impossible, especially with the Devourer active.

The Lady Isolde finishes the letter by asking if Raphael had gathered more information regarding his father's expedition. She also suggests that the House recalls Raphael's cousins - Lyra, Dorian and Selene - from their own pilgrimages and send them to Kroonstad to help him instead.

### HEIR TO THE DRAGON

As the sorcerer and the wizard ponder over their letters, Vilde is escorted by Breakbones to the Senator Arianwen Amadeus.

Vilde, you enter a posh office. Captain Breakbones salutes your mother, who seems to be writing something intently. She dismisses the half-orc without even looking up, and asks her to help fetch your father, Angwyn.

"Good to see you, mummy," Vilde smiles. The Senator ignores her.

"Mummy," Vilde rounds the table, hugging her from the back.

"Sit, please," Senator Arianwen says, continuing her penmanship. As Vilde takes her seat, Breakbones returns with Angwyn.

"Thank you, dear," the Senator says. "And please, shut the door behind you."

"Of course, ma'am," Breakbones salutes as she leaves the room, closing the door behind her.

The Senator produces a small scroll, throwing it in front of Vilde on the desk. "I'm not your carrier pigeon."





"Of course not," Vilde says. "It's just, I realized that *Dawn and Dusk* -"

"What on earth were you thinking?" The Senator demands. "You drugged us and stole a ship and snuck off to the most dangerous jungle in the world with zero explanation, and then sent a note asking us to send over *Dawn and Dusk*? Do you think we're your couriers?"

"No, of course not mummy," Vilde says. "I just didn't want you to have to go on the dangerous Expedition. Do you not trust that I can do it? Do you think I will fail?"

"Vilde, you're my only daughter. I've been training you your whole life to take over me and govern Nike," the Senator continues. "Of course I think you can do it. And I see why you did what you did but do you think the Chamber of Lords-Advisory will just... let me off? If I try to escape the draft, they'll just throw me in prison. The only reason I'm not in a prison cell right now is because I've bought a bit of latitude with them. Tomorrow, you will board the next ship off the continent with your father and head back to Nike, where you will rule in my stead. I'll take over command of the 52nd Expedition."

"What?" Vilde asks, incredulous. "Wait a minute, that makes no sense. Don't you think I'll be a better leader if I get some real-world experience? I'm learning a lot on this Expedition -"

"This is not a discussion," the Senator Arianwen replies. "Either you listen to me, or I post up armed

guards outside your door and forcibly remove you from Kroonstad."

"Yeah, you can try," Vilde seethes. "I'll just kill them."

"Young lady!" The Senator Arianwen raises her voice, furious. "Listen to yourself! Kill them? Will you kill Breakbones, if I post her outside your door? What about Firebeard?"

"I'll just sneak past them," Vilde sulks. "Not like they can catch me."

The Senator leans forward, rubbing her eyes in frustration. Angwyn gently rubs her back, trying to calm Arianwen down.

"And what about you, father?" Vilde says. "Don't you want to help me?"

"Listen to your mother, Vilde," Angwyn says.

#### WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Vilde sees that even though her logic of gaining real-world experience is working on her mummy, the Senator Arianwen Amadeus cannot bring herself to let her daughter take on a deadly mission in her place. Emotionally, the Senator despises herself for even considering letting her daughter die in her place.

"I am very proud of all that you've achieved, Vilde," Arianwen replies. "I really am. But don't ask me to stand by and watch you die. I won't do it."

"You just don't think I can do it," Vilde says quietly. "You don't trust me."

A flash of anger burns across the Senator's face as she realizes Vilde refuses to see her way. "By the way, we've left *Dawn and Dusk* at home," Arianwen says. "You didn't think we'd be stupid enough to bring it here for you to steal and run away, did you?"

#### **WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK**

On a successful DC 15 check, Vilde sees that a guilty look pass over Angwyn's face.

"Are you serious?" Vilde asks. "Daddy? What do you think about all this?"

"Listen to your mother, Vilde," Angwyn says, continuing to rub her mother's back.

"Go," Arianwen says. "Say goodbye to your friends. Tonight's the last time you're going to see them."

Vilde storms out of the room as the Senator collapses into tears, sobbing.